

Mic Testing

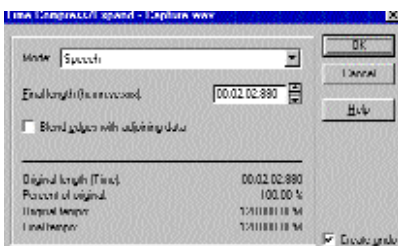
Capturing audio is probably the easiest part of the movie-making process. All you need is a microphone, WAV recording software like SoundForge and a good voice.

Adjust the microphone level from the volume controller until the sound is clear and there is no background noise affecting it. You can also record a clip with variations in pitch and play it back to ensure that it is clear.

Set up SoundForge for recording

Launch SoundForge and click **Special > Record** to bring up the recording options. Click the Record button to begin recording.

To delete parts of the captured audio, simply select the range and press [Delete]. The Process menu has some very useful options to enhance the sound. Normalise, Smooth/Enhance, Time Compress/Expand and Volume will



Create a wave file of the same length as the video

be the ones you'll use most often when editing sound for video. Of these, the most useful one is Time Compress/Expand. Ideally, it is best to have a wave file of the exact same length as the video for perfect synchronisation. Once you have finished editing the sound and kept only the parts you require, use this function to expand or compress the length of the track to match the length of the video. You can get the length of the video from VirtualDub.

For accurate audio-video synchronisation, it is best to have a single final wave file. You can work with multiple audio samples, but once you finalise them, merge them all in sequence into a single track. Merging audio files is as simple as a copy-paste operation.

Great Stills

You can add still images, photographs and computer-generated graphics such as graphs or transitions to your video too. For this, we will use a tool called AVI Assembler. Start AVI Assembler and click



Create video from a set of bitmaps

Add Images.

You can select any BMP, JPG or GIF files and add them to the list. Set the FPS, width and height to the same

frame rate, width and height of the captured video (say, 30, 320 and 240). Images of different sizes will be automatically scaled to this size. In the box for 'This frame should appear... times', set how many frames each image should span across and click 'Input # times'. Multiply the number of seconds the image should be displayed by the FPS to calculate this value. Click **AVI Operations > AVI Parameters** and set the Pixel Format to 24-bit for best video quality. Click Create AVI and choose where the video should be saved.

Creating VCDs: For burning VCDs, you will have to encode the video in MPEG-1 format. Though not as good as DivX, VCDs are more widespread and can be viewed on conventional VCD players. The only other way is to create a completely uncompressed video file, which is not only unwieldy, but may also be impossible—just a 10 minute video can take up to 8 GB of disk space!

Going online: If you are looking to host your video on the Internet, do everything you can to get the file size down to the minimum possible. It would also be a good idea to provide videos of different resolutions and quality so that the viewer may choose depending on his bandwidth. Streaming is a totally different ball game. You would need to install a streaming server and encode the files specifically for streaming. Windows XP comes bundled with Windows Media Tools that allow you to create streaming files. PlayStream

(www.playstream.com) has an impressive set of services for streaming. They can convert and stream video in several formats and though the service is not free, you can get a free trial for 15 days.

Your hammer and nails

You can use various hardware and software to capture and work with digital video. Though digital video (DV) cameras have been around for many years, they have always been unimaginably expensive and used only by professionals. Their prices have reduced over the years, but most are still beyond the reach of amateur enthusiasts. Many digital cameras today provide the added functionality of capturing motion picture. DV cameras afford the best quality and highest amount of control over the capture when shooting a video, but to connect it to your computer, you will also need to invest in an IEEE1394 add-on card.

VirtualDub Filters

Filter	Purpose
Deinterlace	Outputs a non-interlaced video from an interlaced one
Brightness/Contrast	Adjusts brightness and contrast of the video
Levels	Adjusts colour levels of the video
Resize	Re-samples the image resolution (height and width)
Sharpen	Gives more distinct edges to the picture
Smoother	Smoothens out the image and can remove noise from the video
Box Blur	Adds blurring effects in increasing gradations from the centre to the periphery of the frame
Emboss	Creates a 3D embossed image
Flip Horizontally and Flip Vertically	Flips the image horizontally or vertically
Rotate	Rotates the picture by 90, 180 or 270 degrees
Rotate2	Rotates a video by any specified angle. Areas emptied due to the rotation are filled with a solid colour
Invert	Creates a negative of the image
Motion Blur	Adds a motion effect by blurring successive images together